Friedberg, he argues that the US still has a chance to stop Chinese hegemony. Pillsbury went on to advise the Trump administration on China and is credited with the hardening of US policy since 2016. All three analysts share the more or less conventional and accepted view that China is likely to overtake the US – in Friedberg's book, the focus is on who will be dominant in Asia, not globally.

The inexorable rise of China is the orthodox position, and by now most well-educated schoolchildren can recite some version of it. It is useful here to consider the contrasting view. One of the most clearly articulated is that of Michael Beckley, a professor of political science at Tufts University in the US, who has questioned China's supposedly unstoppable rise to number one. His 2016 book is titled *Unrivaled: Why America Will Remain the Sole Superpower*.[13] More than the others, Beckley weighs up the prospects of the two countries carefully, using an array of metrics, and he accepts that the gap is closing in some areas and that the US maintaining its lead is not a given for all time.

In an article published in 2020 in the US journal *Foreign Affairs*, titled 'Rogue Superpower: Why This Could Be an Illiberal American Century', Beckley presents his most recent argument for why China will not match the US in the twenty-first century. The argument rests on demography and automation. According to Beckley, in the next fifty years, the US will be the only country among the top twenty economic powers, along with Australia and Canada, to have a growing population of adults between the age of twenty and forty-nine. His estimate is that China will lose 225 million workers and consumers in that age group, which is more than one-third of the current total (due largely to its ageing population which in turn is the result of its one-child policy going back to 1979). In the US on the other hand those cohorts will grow by ten per cent. As a result, America will have a huge and growing internal market and will be less reliant on foreign trade and investment than China.[14]

Beckley suggests that demography will adversely affect China's military as well. Expenditures on pensions and health for the ageing Chinese population will triple by 2050 whereas this will only increase by 35 per cent